TO: Mayor of Seattle
FROM: Khairy Barnes Evaluator
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SUBJECT: Evaluation of Citizen-State Interactions in South Park

Executive Summary

Following a child's death in South Park caused by gang violence, city officials aimed to tackle these issues by collecting feedback from residents, particularly from Latino communities, to ensure that any changes would genuinely address their needs. This led to hiring Arana to serve as a bridge between Latinos and the city. Citizen-state interactions were facilitated through community meetings, which often lacked significant Latino participation, resulting in unrepresentative input. This disconnect caused a gap between how Arana and other officials understood the needs of Latino residents in South Park and what those residents required. Building organizational networks that connect relevant groups can help overcome barriers to shared knowledge and coordinated action. Additionally, involving affected individuals directly in addressing social problems can make solutions more effective. Whether Arana's challenges stem from her role or from the institutional setup, her initial lack of knowledge about the Latino residents limited her legitimacy, largely because she was assigned to this position without prior connections or awareness, which was not her fault but rather a consequence of her imposed role.

Citizen-State Interaction in South Park

The primary issue with the initial setup of citizen-state interactions was that only individuals of Anglo descent attended meetings, especially those from groups like SPNA and SPARC. Fung's framework in his article "Putting the Public Back into Governance: The Challenges of Citizen Participation and Its Future" suggests evaluating participatory governance by who participates, how participants communicate and make decisions, and how much influence participants exercise over public action. Despite South Park's diverse, multiethnic population, many residents from these communities did not participate regularly. This skewed the focus toward issues highlighted by Anglo Americans, while concerns important to Latino communities were underrepresented. Notably, Asian American voices were largely absent. The city relied on community volunteers to serve as representatives. Problems arose when many community members opted not to volunteer. Moreover, community organizations often had an advantage because they entered meetings with a shared goal and a coordinated plan, unlike individual volunteers from less organized communities, who tended to be less unified and less effective at representing their areas. The Latino community lacked enough cohesion for one person to effectively advocate on its behalf at city events. Initially, government-citizen communication was not truly collaborative: meetings involved residents voicing concerns and the government offering solutions rather than seeking input on community preferences. Though community organizations spoke for many residents, their problem-solving goals often did not align with residents' desires. City officials tended to impose their plans, as seen with the hiring of Arana, who lacked community knowledge. The overall setup allowed only residents to provide input, without fostering meaningful dialogue among community members.

Before Arana's arrival, residents had limited influence in their community. Although South Park residents shared their needs with the city, the local government was unsure how to proceed. Arana's research revealed a long-standing tradition of residents fiercely advocating for their needs, suggesting that, before her arrival, they had few ways to consult with the city. Fung notes that "Frustration, cynicism, or apathy can be the results of a poorly designed public engagement process" (513). Although Latino residents were not formally excluded from City meetings, the City's reliance on existing organizations, voluntary participation, and conventional meeting structures made their participation less consistent and their influence over priorities uncertain. This disconnect, driven by administrative burden, flawed participation mechanisms, and lack of representation, is especially apparent among Latinos, who often wonder whether or how their input would influence city government (13). This skepticism about their impact ultimately stems from poor process design.

A key issue is the administrative burden faced by South Park Latin residents. Moynihan et al. discuss this in their article "Administrative Burden: Learning, Psychological, and Compliance Costs in Citizen-State Interactions," emphasizing learning costs as a major component. These costs involve the effort residents expend to understand the program, determine eligibility, grasp benefits, and access services. Since government procedures in many Latin American countries differ greatly from those in Seattle, Latino residents encountered high learning costs when trying to participate in meetings; many felt excluded (13). Their lack of understanding of how government processes operate prevented them from engaging effectively or representing themselves, thereby hindering their connection to the government.

Residents also experienced psychological impacts, which Moynihan et al. describe as a loss of autonomy and heightened stress caused by program procedures. During many early meetings, Arana noted that participants often responded with anger, saying, "'Who are you? You're not the mayor! We've been telling the city what we need for years. You should have been listening'" (7). Despite residents repeatedly communicating their needs, frustration grew when city officials finally understood these concerns, as residents felt they had already voiced them. This frustration intensified when Arana presented her initial action plan, eliciting more backlash. Residents believed they had no say in funding decisions or community governance, leading to feelings of helplessness. The psychological toll inflicted by the state on South Park residents reduced Latino representation, fostering frustration and hopelessness. The salience and complexity of the problem in South Park led to pressure for accountability. Gormley, W., Jr. emphasizes this in his article "Regulatory Issue Networks in a Federal System." Residents perceive the city as trying to resolve the issue without acknowledging the process that brought them to this point, which heightens their frustration. Ultimately, this dynamic created specific costs for residents, influencing their participation and reactions during city engagement initiatives.

Alternative Configuration

To improve the alternative configuration, key issues include who participates, how they communicate, and their influence. Initially, meetings in South Park mainly involved Anglo residents, with little diversity. An important change could involve "individual engagement," as Fung describes, emphasizing that social problems often originate from individual issues, and

solutions are possible when those individuals are involved. This entails providing Latino residents in South Park space to collaborate and propose solutions to the city. This design fosters intentional communication with the government and strengthens residents' influence. Another beneficial change is adopting 'Multisectoral problem solving," which involves organizations sharing knowledge and coordinating efforts to tackle issues more effectively. Arana's formation of neighborhood committees mirrors this approach, encouraging the Latino community to organize, set specific goals, and collaborate with others. The previous system suffered from poor communication among groups with differing priorities and disorganized Latino residents, leading to fragmented complaints and confusion among officials, which caused the neglect of the Latino community and increased racial tension. However, some positive outcomes emerged. Before Arana's leadership, South Park residents had limited influence over City decision-making. By establishing proper representation and creating a committee for the Latino community to deliberate with others, they developed an action plan that significantly advanced neighborhood development.

Claudia Arana

Arana had significant freedom to shape the citizen-state relationship based on her own judgment, as the mayor usually supported her requests. Replacing her with another agent separates her personal discretion as a citizen-agent from the typical state-agent role, which centers on rules and institutional authority. This difference can lead to very different outcomes depending on the new agent's discretion. Maynard-Moody & Musheno emphasize this in their article "State Agent or Citizen Agent: Two Narratives of Discretion," noting that discretion is inevitable because street-level workers must make decisions based on specific situations that rules cannot fully address (338). The inevitability of discretion means selecting agents whose circumstances best fit the job. Arana's discretion is driven by unique factors: her commitment to social justice, her selection because the mayor believed Latino residents could relate to her, her newcomer status in City government, and the professional pressure of her first major assignment. All these factors are specific to her. The case's structural factors, however, remain constant: The Mayor's Office assigned an agent to a neighborhood to gauge residents' needs after the June 1 meeting revealed widespread fear, anger, and disconnection from government. City officials acknowledged that the existing planning process had not sufficiently included the neighborhood's newer Latino and immigrant populations. The new agent would need to address distrust, neighborhood divisions, the City's historical neglect, participation rules, institutional authority, and the City's relationship with residents. Replacing Arana could have changed how the City interacted with residents because the position afforded substantial discretion. However, a different representative would still have faced the same underlying institutional conditions, so personnel changes alone were unlikely to resolve South Park's citizen-state problems.

Recommendation

The South Park experience shows that effective citizen-state engagement depends not only on government officials listening to residents but also on how participation is structured. The City's initial approach relied heavily on existing organizations and residents already connected to government, leaving significant portions of the Latino community underrepresented. As a result, residents faced learning and psychological costs that made meaningful participation more

difficult and contributed to frustration and distrust. The central problem, therefore, was not simply a lack of communication but a participation structure that did not adequately reflect South Park's diversity or give all residents meaningful influence over decisions affecting their community.

Future engagement should prioritize broader representation, opportunities for residents to deliberate among themselves, and stronger connections between community organizations and City officials. Creating spaces where underrepresented residents can organize around shared concerns would allow the City to gather more representative knowledge and give residents greater influence over the priorities developed for their neighborhood. Arana’s experience demonstrates that individual officials can use discretion to improve these relationships, but individual effort cannot fully overcome institutional barriers. The Mayor’s Office should therefore treat effective engagement as an issue of institutional design rather than relying solely on individual representatives to bridge gaps between government and residents.